

WG02

Rivers and Lakes of the World

About 1 question a paper out of the 3-question world geography slot. It is nearly always a match-the-following or a NOT-correctly-matched pair. Canals, straits and lake superlatives are the safest bets.

This chapter is pure matching - river to continent, river to outfall, city to river, lake to superlative, strait to the two land masses it separates. There is nothing to understand and everything to fix in memory. Read the tables aloud twice; that is how these marks are won.

Rivers & Lakes of the World

Longest

- Nile
- Amazon
- Yangtze
- Mississippi-Missouri
- Yenisei

Outfalls

- Volga-Caspian
- Danube-Black Sea
- Congo-Atlantic
- Huang He-Bohai

Cities on rivers

- Paris-Seine
- London-Thames
- Rome-Tiber
- Berlin-Spree

Waterfalls

- Angel
- Victoria
- Niagara
- Iguazu
- Boyoma

Canals & straits

- Suez
- Panama
- Kiel
- Bering
- Malacca
- Hormuz

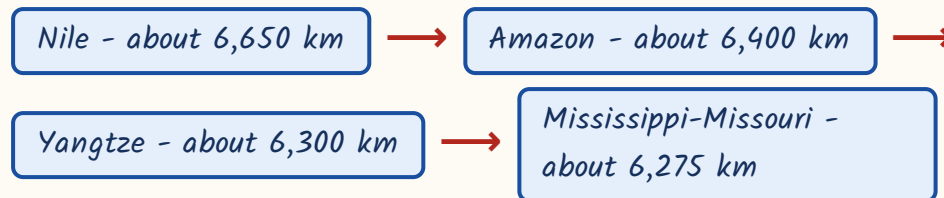
Lakes

- Caspian
- Superior
- Baikal
- Victoria
- Titicaca
- Dead Sea

Length, discharge, basin - three different questions

Before the tables, settle one confusion. 'Longest' is about length. 'Largest' can mean discharge or basin area. The Nile is the longest river of the world; the Amazon is the largest by both volume of water and basin area. If a question says 'carries the largest volume of water to the sea', the answer is the Amazon, never the Nile.

Descending order of river length



- Nile - longest in the world and in Africa; rises in the East African highlands via the Kagera.
- Amazon - rises in the Peruvian Andes, drains to the Atlantic; largest drainage basin on earth.
- Yangtze - longest river of Asia and the longest flowing wholly within one country.
- Congo (about 4,700 km) - the only major river that crosses the Equator twice; the world's deepest river.
- Volga (about 3,645 km) - longest river of Europe, entirely inside Russia.
- Danube - second longest in Europe; passes through 10 countries and 4 capital cities.

YAAD RAKHO

For the length order remember N-A-Y-M: Nile, Amazon, Yangtze, Mississippi-Missouri. Four numbers all between 6,200 and 6,700 km - so learn the order, not the figures.

River to continent to outfall - the master tables

This is the table the matching question is built from. Do it continent by continent. Notice the pattern in Siberia - every big Russian river of Asia runs north into the Arctic. Notice too that two giants, the Congo and the Amazon, end in estuaries and not deltas.

Africa and the Americas

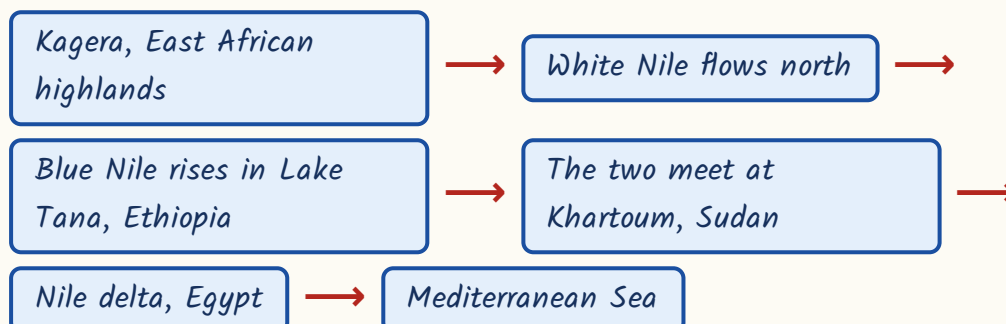
River	Continent	Drains into
Nile	Africa	Mediterranean Sea, through a large delta in Egypt
Congo	Africa	Atlantic Ocean, through an estuary
Niger	Africa	Gulf of Guinea
Zambezi	Africa	Indian Ocean; forms the Victoria Falls
Orange	Africa	Atlantic Ocean
Limpopo	Africa	Indian Ocean
Amazon	South America	Atlantic Ocean, through an estuary
Parana - Rio de la Plata (about 4,880 km)	South America	Atlantic Ocean; second longest of the continent
Orinoco	South America	Atlantic Ocean, Venezuela
Sao Francisco	South America	Atlantic Ocean, Brazil
Mississippi-Missouri	North America	Gulf of Mexico, bird's-foot delta
Mackenzie	North America	Beaufort Sea (Arctic)
Yukon	North America	Bering Sea
Colorado	North America	Gulf of California

Asia, Europe and Australia

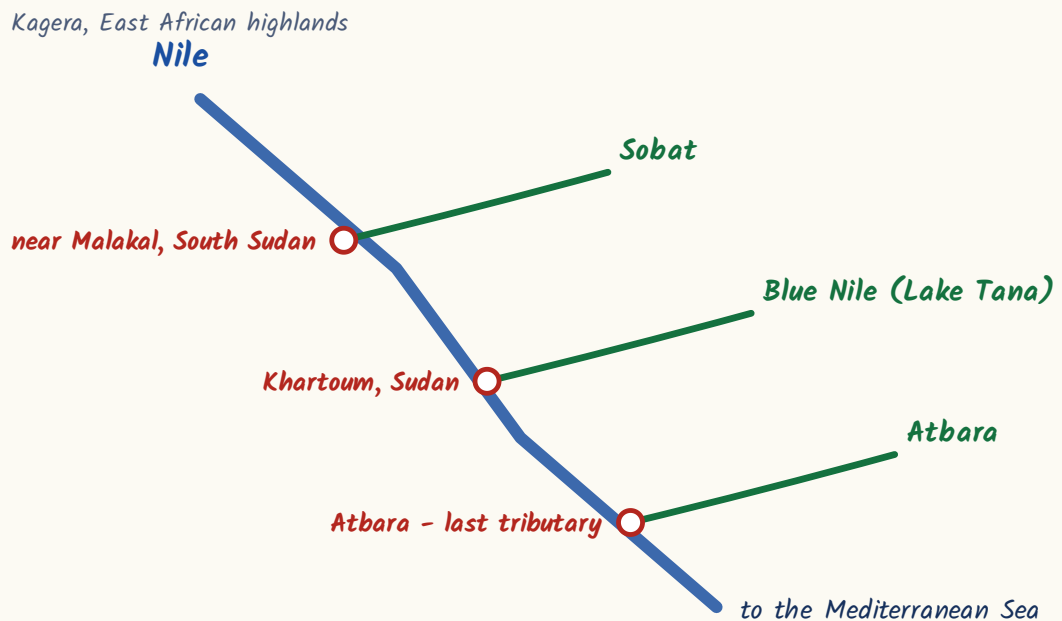
River	Continent	Drains into
Yangtze	Asia	East China Sea
Huang He (Yellow)	Asia	Bohai Sea
Mekong	Asia	South China Sea
Ob-Irtysh (5,410 km)	Asia	Gulf of Ob, Arctic
Yenisei (5,539 km)	Asia	Kara Sea, Arctic
Lena (4,400 km)	Asia	Laptev Sea, Arctic
Tigris and Euphrates	Asia	Persian Gulf, after uniting as the Shatt al-Arab in southern Iraq
Volga	Europe	Caspian Sea
Danube	Europe	Black Sea
Rhine	Europe	North Sea, at Rotterdam
Rhone	Europe	Mediterranean Sea
Murray-Darling	Australia	Southern Ocean; longest river system of Australia

- Huang He - the 'Sorrow of China' because of its floods; carries a huge load of loess.
- St. Lawrence drains the Great Lakes into the Atlantic.
- Mekong flows through China, Myanmar, Laos, Thailand, Cambodia and Vietnam.
- Ganga-Brahmaputra delta (the Sundarbans) is the world's largest delta.

Course of the Nile - the confluence question



The Nile and its tributaries



TRAP

Delta or estuary? The Congo and the Amazon discharge through estuaries, not true deltas, even though they are enormous. The Mississippi has a bird's-foot delta and the Ganga-Brahmaputra has the largest delta of all.

Cities on rivers

Every capital in Europe grew on a river. RPSC picks four of them and asks you to match, or gives one wrong pair and asks which is wrong. The Danube alone carries four capitals - that fact by itself answers several questions.

City to river

City	River	Country
Paris	Seine	France
London	Thames	United Kingdom
Rome	Tiber	Italy

City	River	Country
Berlin	Spree	Germany
Hamburg	Elbe	Germany
Warsaw	Vistula	Poland
Rotterdam	Rhine	Netherlands
Vienna	Danube	Austria
Bratislava	Danube	Slovakia
Budapest	Danube	Hungary
Belgrade	Danube	Serbia
Cairo	Nile	Egypt
Khartoum	Blue Nile and White Nile meet here	Sudan
Baghdad	Tigris	Iraq

TRAP

Paris stands on the Seine, not the Rhine. That exact swap is the standard wrong option. Similarly Hamburg is on the Elbe, Rotterdam on the Rhine - do not merge the two German cities.

Waterfalls, deltas and confluences

Waterfalls are asked as height, river or country. Only four names really matter: Angel is the highest, Boyoma has the greatest volume, Victoria is the famous one on the Zambezi, and Niagara sits on the USA-Canada border.

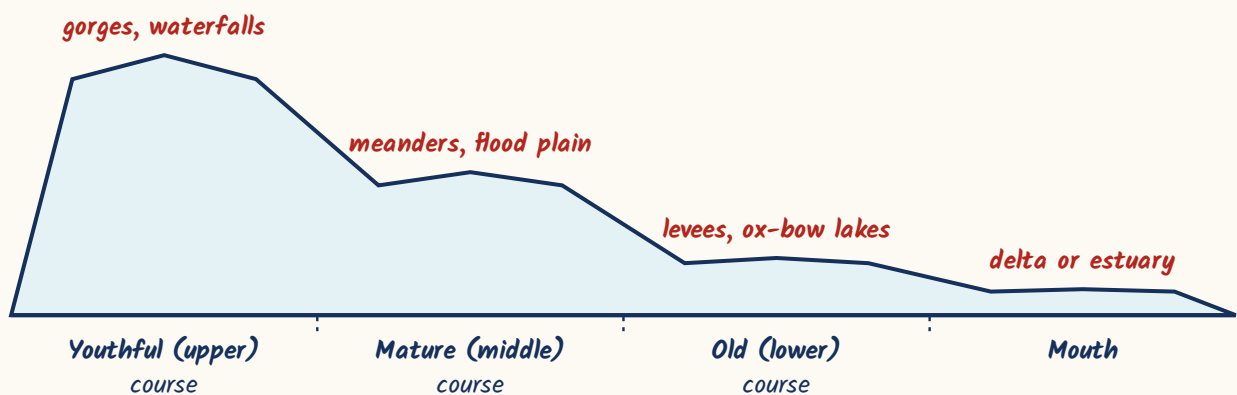
Waterfall to river and country

Waterfall	River	Country
Angel (979 m) - world's highest	Falls from the Auyan-tepui into a tributary of the Churun	Venezuela (Canaima National Park)
Tugela - second highest	Tugela	South Africa

Waterfall	River	Country
Victoria - 'Mosi-oa-Tunya', the smoke that thunders	Zambezi	Zambia - Zimbabwe border
Niagara	Niagara	USA - Canada
Iguazu	Iguazu	Argentina - Brazil
Boyoma - greatest volume of any waterfall	Congo	DR Congo

- Angel Falls is a plunge of 979 m - the height figure is the examinable bit.
- Victoria Falls lies on the Zambezi, which then flows on to the Indian Ocean.
- Iguazu and Niagara are both border falls - remember the country pairs.
- Boyoma wins on discharge, not height.

Long profile of a river - the three stages



ASKED IN RAS

RPSC's world geography slot is a matching slot - RAS Pre 2016, 2018 and 2021 used mountain peaks, RAS Pre 2024 used deserts. Rivers and waterfalls sit in the same rotation, so treat 'Angel-Venezuela', 'Victoria-Zambezi' and 'Boyoma-Congo' as pairs to be recalled instantly rather than as facts to be reasoned out.

Canals and straits

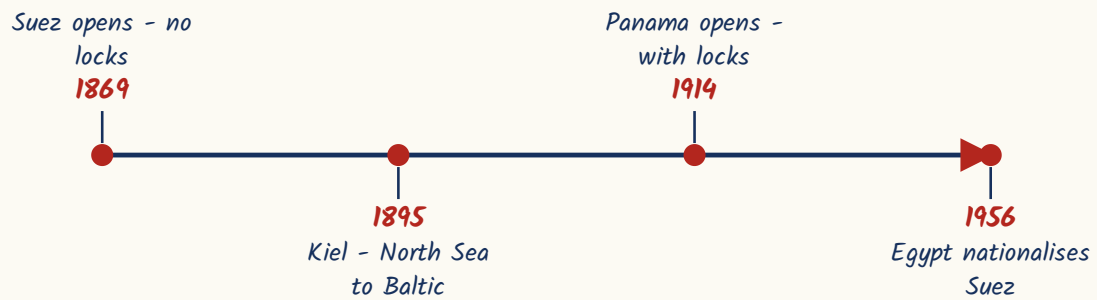
Two canals are asked again and again, and the distinction between them is the whole question: Suez has no locks, Panama has locks. Learn the years, the lengths and the water bodies each one joins.

Suez Canal vs Panama Canal

Suez Canal	Panama Canal
Opened 1869	Opened 1914
About 193 km long	About 82 km long
Joins the Mediterranean (Port Said) to the Red Sea (Suez)	Joins the Atlantic Ocean to the Pacific Ocean
A sea-level canal with no locks	Works through a system of locks that lift ships to Gatun Lake
Nationalised by Egypt in 1956	Cuts the Panama isthmus of Central America

- Kiel Canal - opened 1895, about 98 km, joins the North Sea to the Baltic Sea in Germany.
- Suez shortens the Europe-Asia route by removing the voyage round the Cape of Good Hope.
- Panama removes the voyage round Cape Horn at the tip of South America.

The great canals in order



Straits - what they separate and what they connect

Strait	Separates	Connects
Bering	Asia and North America	Pacific and Arctic oceans
Gibraltar	Europe and Africa	Mediterranean Sea and Atlantic Ocean
Malacca	Sumatra and the Malay peninsula	Andaman Sea and South China Sea
Hormuz	Iran and the Arabian peninsula	Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman
Bab-el-Mandeb	Arabia and Africa	Red Sea and Gulf of Aden
Bosphorus	Asian and European Turkey	Black Sea and Sea of Marmara
Magellan	Mainland South America and Tierra del Fuego	Atlantic and Pacific oceans
Palk Strait	India and Sri Lanka	Palk Bay and the Bay of Bengal side

CURRENT LINK

Current link: the Panama Canal depends on fresh water from Gatun Lake, and the El Nino drought of 2023-24 forced the canal authority to cut daily transits and tighten draft limits; conditions eased through 2025. As of September 2026 this is the standing example of climate stress on a trade route - useful for any canal or shipping question.

CURRENT LINK

Current link: the Suez Canal has been hit by the Red Sea shipping crisis. After attacks on merchant ships from late 2023 most container lines went back to the long route round the Cape of Good Hope, and Egypt reported canal revenue falling by about 60 per cent in 2024, to roughly USD 4 billion from about USD 10 billion the year before. As of September 2026 the Red Sea diversion is the standing example of a choke point losing its traffic - pair it with the Panama drought.

ASKED IN RAS

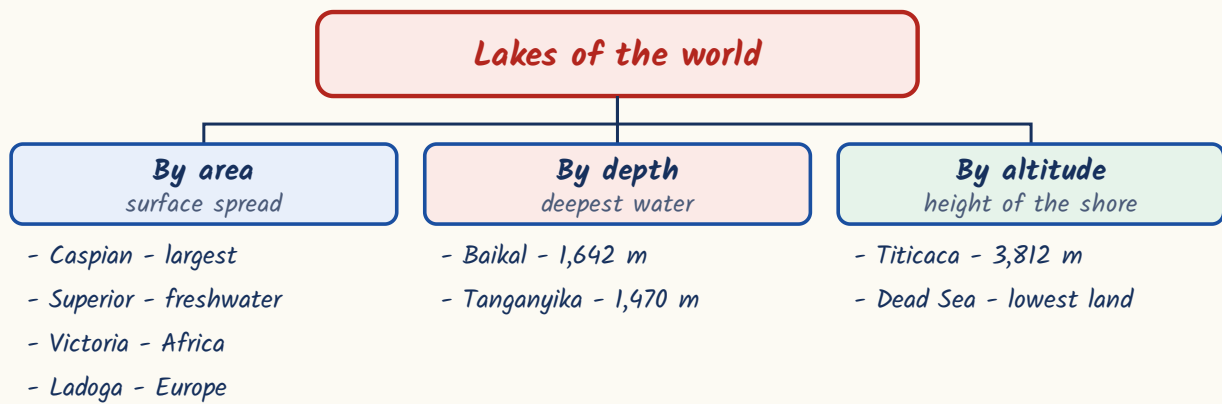
The bank's NOT-correctly-matched question on canals turns on one line: 'Panama Canal - a sea-level canal without locks' is FALSE. It is Suez that has no locks. Expect the same trick with 1869 and 1914 swapped.

Lakes - superlatives and types

Lakes are asked as superlatives. There are four big ones and they are four different lakes - largest, deepest, largest freshwater, highest navigable.

Confusing them is the commonest mistake. After the superlatives, learn how lakes are formed, because 'lake to type' is the matching version of the same question.

Four superlatives, four different lakes



Lake superlatives

Superlative	Lake	Detail
Largest lake on earth by area	Caspian Sea	About 3.7 lakh sq km; landlocked salt lake shared by Russia, Kazakhstan, Turkmenistan, Iran, Azerbaijan
Largest freshwater lake by area	Lake Superior	82,100 sq km, North America
Deepest lake, and largest freshwater lake by volume	Lake Baikal	1,642 m; tectonic rift lake in Siberia; about a fifth of the world's unfrozen surface fresh water
Second deepest, and longest freshwater lake	Lake Tanganyika	1,470 m, East Africa
Largest lake of Africa	Lake Victoria	About 69,000 sq km; second largest freshwater lake by area
Largest lake of Europe	Lake Ladoga	Russia
Highest navigable lake	Lake Titicaca	3,812 m, on the Peru-Bolivia border
Lowest exposed land surface on earth	Dead Sea shore	About 430 m below sea level
Largest salt lake and lowest point of Australia	Lake Eyre	South Australia

Lakes by type of origin

Type	Examples
Tectonic (rift or downwarped)	Baikal, Tanganyika, Dead Sea
Crater or caldera	Crater Lake (USA), Toba (Indonesia)
Glacial	The Great Lakes of North America
Ox-bow (fluvial)	Cut-off meanders on flood plains
Lagoon (coastal)	Enclosed by sand bars along the coast
Artificial (reservoir)	Lake Volta (Ghana), Lake Nasser (Egypt)

- Aral Sea (Kazakhstan-Uzbekistan) shrank drastically after the Amu Darya and Syr Darya were diverted for cotton irrigation.
- Lake Chad is shared by Chad, Niger, Nigeria and Cameroon.
- Sargasso Sea in the North Atlantic is the only sea with no coastline - it is bounded by the currents of the North Atlantic gyre.

YAAD RAKHO

Four superlatives, four different lakes: Caspian largest, Baikal deepest, Superior largest freshwater by area, Titicaca highest navigable. And Lake Malawi is NOT the deepest - that wrong option appears in the bank.

ASKED IN RAS

Because the world geography slot rotates through matching sets - peaks in 2016, 2018 and 2021, deserts in 2024 - lakes and straits are the obvious untouched pool. The two sets worth over-learning are the lake superlatives above and the strait table: Bering (Asia-North America), Gibraltar (Europe-Africa), Malacca, Hormuz, Bab-el-Mandeb, Palk.

REVISION RECAP

1. Nile longest (about 6,650 km); Amazon largest in discharge and basin area; Yangtze longest in Asia and within one country.
2. Length order: Nile > Amazon > Yangtze > Mississippi-Missouri.

3. Congo crosses the Equator twice, is the deepest river, and ends in an estuary like the Amazon.
4. Volga - longest in Europe, into the Caspian; Danube - 10 countries, 4 capitals, into the Black Sea.
5. Siberian rivers run north: Ob-Irtysh to the Gulf of Ob, Yenisei to the Kara Sea, Lena to the Laptev Sea.
6. Huang He = 'Sorrow of China', loess-laden, into the Bohai Sea; Mekong into the South China Sea.
7. Tigris and Euphrates unite as the Shatt al-Arab and enter the Persian Gulf.
8. Blue Nile (Lake Tana) meets the White Nile at Khartoum; Sundarbans is the world's largest delta.
9. Cities: Paris-Seine, London-Thames, Rome-Tiber, Berlin-Spree, Hamburg-Elbe, Warsaw-Vistula, Cairo-Nile.
10. Angel (979 m, Venezuela) highest; Boyoma greatest volume; Victoria on the Zambezi; Iguazu Argentina-Brazil.
11. Suez 1869, 193 km, Mediterranean to Red Sea, no locks; Panama 1914, 82 km, Atlantic to Pacific, locks and Gatun Lake.
12. Kiel Canal 1895, 98 km, North Sea to Baltic.
13. Straits: Bering Asia-North America, Gibraltar Europe-Africa, Hormuz Persian Gulf-Gulf of Oman, Palk India-Sri Lanka.
14. Caspian largest lake, Superior largest freshwater by area, Baikal deepest and largest by volume, Titicaca highest navigable.
15. Aral Sea shrank from cotton irrigation on the Amu Darya and Syr Darya; Sargasso is the sea without a coastline.